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Béla Fleck

Béla Fleck was born in New York City on July 10, 1958. He has transformed the traditional role of the banjo while creating his own distinctive musical genre with the Flecktones. Béla has enjoyed musical collaborations with artists such as Bruce Hornsby, Chic Corea and Branford Marsalis, and he has received multiple Grammy awards for his recordings and compositions.

Béla was interviewed before a performance at Hamilton in Clinton on December 7, 2004 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive on campus and I'm really pleased to have Béla Fleck with me today. Welcome.

BF: Thank you. Nice to be here.

MR: It's a real pleasure. I've been thinking lately, my family ranges from about twenty years old to, well I'm about eight years your senior. And we all really like your music. And I've been trying to figure out how you manage to do that.

BF: Oh. I don't know. But I'm glad too. I really like that about what's been happening with the music is that we have children and old folks and everything in between that like it. That means a lot to us.

MR: When you set about writing new compositions, does the fact that you had three or four fourth members affect the way you're thinking about new work?

BF: Not so much. Like I just write a lot. And I'm always screwing around with the banjo and stuff pops out and then I try to figure out what's going to be good for the group. And a lot of times I just take what I think is the best song and what makes it the best song to me is hard to put my finger on but I'll just have something and I'll think well this is — there a bunch, I might have twenty things that I come up with, this one I think is special. It's usually something about the melody or the chords that's different enough to either be — it has to either be so simple and strong and striking in its simplicity that it's better than the other simple tunes that I've written or that the other guys have or whatever, or it's got to have a complexity that's interesting but not necessarily offputting. Just I'm looking for a certain intangible something. But when I find it I know it. And I always believe — by the time I've brought a tune to the band, they may not know it but I'm usually deeply committed to it. And I'm just going to put it out there and sort of see what happens. But deep down I'm just going to start problem solving immediately and try to figure out, okay what's not working, what is working, how can Jeff's role be made better, is he dominating too much or is he — because a lot of times our fourth person is usually our melody player, which would usually be the leader in most bands. So to find a melody

player who's willing to fit into the group and find a way to make the whole group sound good. And he's actually the guest sort of. He shouldn't be the dominant figure. He should be an equal fourth at best. Or right in there. Because I mean the other three guys have been together for sixteen years. He's only been here for — I mean it's a delicate balance. And yet he needs to come forward and be strong and be a powerful musician that can stand up there with us and be dominant as well. So it's a very tricky position for that fourth person. It always has been ever since Howard left.

MR: Is there a balancing of egos involved?

BF: Absolutely. Because anybody that's going to play with us, I mean I'll sound like an egotistical guy, but they have to be really good musicians. They have to be strong. They have to have their own career too. They have to be a guy who has a strong leadership ability. Everyone in our group is a leader, really. So when you've got somebody like that they may be used to calling the shots. But that's not really their role in that situation. I have to be that guy because I'm the guy with the overview of this particular music that we're doing as a four piece group. Not that anybody else in the group wouldn't have equally good input or overview on their own music, but for this stuff I have an instinct for it. And I've come to terms with it. And it's been difficult for me because I'm not a dominant person in general but I've learned to fight for it if I think it's not going the right way, and that my instincts are very solid about this particular version of music that we do together that's the Flecktones. I wouldn't say it's better than anybody else's as it regards the music that they're working or even at times in our music, but as a general overview I've learned to trust my instincts.

MR: You had made a statement in an interview I saw about you felt your music was simple on a symbolic level. Can you expand on that? I think it's a really interesting statement.

BF: I don't know the context.

MR: Well I think they were asking about that a lot of the material you write and perform is pretty complex from chord structures and melodies, and then when you guys start improvising it can get very complex. Yet you still felt that there was a simplicity about it that people who might not understand it technically can still like –

BF: Right. All right. Well it just depends what you're comparing it to. Because I mean if you're listening to great classical music or if you're listening to different kinds of jazz through different periods or Indian music, our music would be just pretty simple. You know what I mean? So it depends on the context of what you're comparing it to. I mean if you're used to listening to jam bands, or just straight ahead bebop just in four-four that's complex in the soloing, but the rest of it, the structures can be, I don't think any of them are very complex. I really don't. I think we're always looking for a simple, like if we're looking for a seven, if we're going to play in seven, we're looking for a seven that

feels like it's in four. If we're looking for an eleven, we want it to feel like it's in four. We want to find a way to make what seem to be more complex forms feel very natural and comfortable. But that's something people have been doing for a long time too. So I'm very aware of the overall context of music, the centuries of music or as much of it as I've been exposed to and what's actually new about our group is probably just a combination of things that haven't come together before. But in terms of reinventing music, no. We're not on that level. I think there's people that are, but no, what I think is unique about us is the combination of influences that have come together into a different, very personal mixture that's expresses who we are as people. And so that, I love that about our band. That to me is our achievement, is that we've been able to keep it together and keep developing as musicians. Everybody's still getting better as players and we're getting better at playing as a group. And those are the things that I'm most proud of. But I mean I play some Bach, and I know what that is, and I've never written anything on a level of that complexity or depth. I don't see myself in that way. But I think what we're doing is personal. And I'm proud of that.

MR: I really enjoyed a couple of things on "Live Art" that stuck out. When you nailed — there's a vocal tune on there, "O Darlin'" and when you nailed that six-eight groove, and then, later on in the CD you start playing a folk song from North Korea. To me that's like, well this man has heard and absorbed an awful lot of music.

BF: Well I love music but to me it's more all similar than it is different. It's not that — I mean a great folk tune from the United States and a great folk tune from North Korea aren't that different. And when you hear this version of it you can hear that pretty clearly. Like that Korean tune is a simple pentatonic tune and we have tons of them here so it's just a different tune. You're just learning the tune. It's not — I mean there are things that we've done that I think are like an achievement and for me like on "Live Art" — not "Live Art" on "Live at the Quick," practicing and working with Sandip Burman on Indian formulas to come up with this and rhythms that come out that were correct in an Indian rhythmic structure, that took a lot of hard work. That didn't follow the folk patterns or the bluegrass patterns or the jazz patterns or the things that I understood. You know what I mean? Or things like there's a piece on the last album that Future Man and I wrote together called "New Math" that involved laying different rhythmic structures on top of other structures. Like playing in four-four but then superimposing a five on top of it, really, really fast, and then superimpose, then going up to six, seven, eight over that same rhythm while keeping the basic pulse the same. That took some work. But learning some beautiful folk tunes in different countries, that happened fast. It was easy, it was natural as it could be, and it was really fun.

MR: And it's a nice sort of release when it comes in the record I think.

BF: Yeah, I think it just shows up — there's just beautiful music everywhere. It's just part of listening and checking it out.

MR: Are there times when you write and you write a hook that you think, this is — I mean it's probably hard to be objective about your own writing — but do you think like yeah, I really have something good here?

BF: Yes I do. I totally get in love with, and in fact I feel like as a writer you're trying to write something you can fall in love with that you can be emotional about and stand behind. And not everything that I write did I feel that way about. But by the time I've written constantly over a year and then there's a few tunes that I go, I keep thinking about that one tune that I wrote, that tune, so maybe if I'm still thinking about it maybe it's good. Maybe it's because I'm always careful about not becoming emotionally involved with stuff. I don't want to like play a pretty progression and then get attached to it just because it might be the most hackneyed progression you've ever heard but if you play it for two hours suddenly you get all emotionally involved. And I don't want it to be like that. I want it to really be good. And so I'm careful when I get emotionally involved with something to make sure and step back from it and then play it again and see if I can still get in that place, if it's going to have that kind of power, if the right pieces of things come together it will have that power, but I just want to be careful that if you're going to play something beautiful it's not just beautiful because it's in the right tempo and has the right chords, it actually is beautiful and you'll hear it that way. You know what I mean?

MR: On repeated listening.

BF: I don't want it to be cheap. I want it to be for real. I want it to really be a beautiful melody and not just people — because you can lull people into that state just by playing a certain groove and a certain type of chord progression and at a gig they'll go, "oh that was so beautiful" but you know it could be garbage. So I mean I have this sort of process I go through of listening to my own things, and like they have to get past me.

MR: Okay.

BF: That's all I'm saying.

MR: Is there a danger in using electronics or great sounding reverbs and stuff? Because you fall in love with the reverb rather than the music.

BF: Yeah. Sure. But I mean unless you use it as part of what makes you create that music. Like for instance Victor does things with the JamMan Looper. And that's technical thing, but what he does with it is so musical that by the end of it it's — it used to strike me that way as being like a technical, like being — it was never cheesy but to me it was less interesting than hearing him play when he didn't use the looper. But as he just stuck with it and years went by, gradually he developed these things that were like really heavy.

Learned to do really interesting things that I really like. So sometimes using an effect can launch you into a whole other musical place.

MR: Do you have trouble thinking of titles sometimes?

BF: Yeah. I'm really picky about titles, and usually the crunch is when it's time for the record to come out, that's when the titles have to get settled. So I keep a list of titles now in my computer and I'll look through them. And often I don't find anything that fits the song. I want it to really fit. And again, why it fits the song, I can't tell you, but when it's the right one it clicks in and I go, oh, that feels right.

MR: Now "Sunset Road" is I think one of your really — it sticks in your head. And there's something really evocative about that song, it reminds me of a song like "Harlem Nocturne" or something that I don't know why that makes me think of someplace. But does it strike you that way?

BF: Yeah. I mean I was really happy with it. It popped out. I was recording an album called "Solo Banjo Works" back whenever it was, before the Flecktones. And I was testing the microphones and I just was improvising a little bit and that melody came out and I just kept playing it over and over again. My brother was recording it, my older brother. And he said, "are you going to get onto what we're going to record?" I said, "yeah I just want to capture this because I think this is good." And so I just kept it and put it aside and then I was looking for a bridge for the longest time. And then finally I came up with a bridge. And then the title came from a signpost. We were driving on the bus and I was sitting in the front early in the morning. We were driving through someplace in South Carolina, and I was looking for titles for that first — I might have still be in New Grass Revival possibly, the band before the Flecktones. Because we had made the Flecktone record and I was on tour looking for titles. And I saw that sign go by, "Sunset Road." That one's done.

MR: When you're working on some of those modulations — not modulations, really the cadences in that song, some of them go where you think, and some of them don't. Do you consciously think about that? Like I know I could go here —

BF: When I'm writing, sure, yeah. Yeah, you want a certain amount of the expected and then a certain amount of unexpected in a good composition I think is to put it really simply. Yeah, I mean I want there to be surprises but I don't want them to be necessarily jarring. Well sometimes I want them to be jarring. You could lull somebody into a sense of security and then vamm — switch into a whole different thing. And that can be really exhilarating to listen to. But it depends. Like with that one there's some nice harmonic stuff in the bridge that when I first wrote it I thought it was a bit esoteric but the more we played it over and over and got into it and got to know it actually wasn't very esoteric and

it wouldn't even qualify as complex harmony. But it was a surprise from what the verse was.

MR: Is there a story behind "Sinister Minister?"

BF: Not really. We were just looking for a title and I think Howard Levy came up with it and we all thought that was funny. And anytime someone had a title that made us laugh we tried to use it.

MR: Okay. The titles can put a spin on things that may not be your intention.

BF: Yeah. But it seemed to fit the song perfectly. It made the song more than what the song was before it had that title. I don't know how. I don't know why. It worked that way with "Sunset Road" too. And I think "Big Country." Sometimes when you get a really classic title for a song the song has that much more — there's another connection for the listener. It's not, "oh what's that song, cut eleven on whatever record, I like that song whatever that was." It's like "I like 'Big Country.' I like 'Sinister Minister.'" It's a connect. So a title is really important. I always wondered whether Béla Fleck and the Flecktones was the best name for the band. It just seemed like the right one at the time and then we were in and it was too late to re-think it. But I think some people think, many people think it was some like California jazz, contemporary jazz thing or something, or like some silly — you know, the graphics and the covers, they made it take us less seriously for some people. But it's worked out.

MR: A successful band makes for a good name I think.

BF: Right. The Beatles was the classic, right.

MR: The Beatles and The Cars.

BF: Yeah. But I mean it does sound like — you know, it's like the Flintstones, if it's going to be wacky, you know. And it is wacky a little bit. You know we've got our crazy drummer guy that plays the synth-axe with his fingers and you've got the banjo player playing in the jazz group and we had a harmonica player for a long time who played piano at the same time. Victor spinning the bass. There was that sort of carnival aspect to the music. But as time goes on I think we more and more want to make sure the music is soulful and meaningful to us and we're less and less — I mean for one thing we don't ever think about radio anymore. There was a period in the beginning where there was always that possibility that a song like "Sinister Minister" might get airplay. Or like we had a big video on that song, which did great things for the group. It got us on television, built us an audience very quickly. And then from then on the next several records there was always the possibility if we came up with a certain song that maybe that would happen again and it would go to the next level. And of course the record company really wanted to see that happen. So we sort of listened to that and think about that a little bit. But more and more we don't get airplay and nothing like that happens and our audience has come

to like us for being different. And I remember all the things with Phish for instance. People would say, "oh go see them live, the records are sell-outs." I don't ever want anybody to say that about us, whether it was true or not, I never thought it was true. I thought Phish made cool records. They were fun. The records were nice. But you know what I mean? So where people mistrust you because of your motives. What are your motives? You can hear when somebody does a record and you listen to it you can tell within twenty seconds what the motives are behind recording that piece of music, whether it's for artistic reasons or whether it's for commercial reasons. You can tell instantly. I promise you, you can. You can tell.

MR: Is there something —

BF: And I don't want that. I mean I don't want that at all.

MR: You don't want people to think of your music as being created to —

BF: As being calculated. Being calculated to sell records or to reach a certain audience. That's just not what — we don't have to do that. We're just really fortunate that we don't have to do that.

MR: Do you get pressure from your record companies to, "Gee, if you guys could just sing" or, "if you could write another song like that."

BF: I don't understand why I'm not getting that pressure. I mean we're on SONY, they're spending this big money. Our sales haven't been that great. They have not put the phone down. Maybe it's because we're near the end of the deal and they want to re-sign us, I don't know. But no, I've been very surprised, honestly. I don't understand it, because I don't think our records are making money for them but I think we're probably the best seller they have right now on their jazz roster so maybe — I don't know what it is. I mean the people keep shifting at the labels too. You know there's been a lot of firings, there's all kinds of stuff. But it always seems like we should be on a major label. I thought that was cool. But now in a time when most people think it's not cool to be on a major label as a banjo player, being on the major label, I mean there was only one other one that ever was for the longest time and that was Earl Scruggs. So to me I thought it was cool to be such an esoteric group, but making it on the majors. And maybe that time is going to pass but I still always thought it was kind of cool to be on it.

MR: Have you ever been tempted to do more vocal work?

BF: I'm not opposed to it. We tried it for a while and it was because I wrote a bunch of songs and that was one of the things that triggered that whole conversation again for the first time in a long time, it's oh we've got Dave Matthews on your record and you're singing this stuff and like are you trying to make pop records? What are you guys trying to do? This isn't why we buy Flecktone records is to hear this stuff. And I remember there was a song we had called "Communication," which at the time I wrote it about a period when

we weren't communicating very well in the band. It was a very simple thing. Communication is the only way to start saying what you mean to say. It's the kind of thing if Sting sang people would say, "oh what a great simple lyric." But because it was my first song on a record people said "wow, what an idiotic lyric."

[pause for cell phone ringing]

BF: Okay well I'm babbling. I don't know what we were into. Oh we were into —

BF: Oh about commerciality. So we do this song with Dave Matthews, who became a big friend of the band's. We toured and did a bunch of shows with him so it was a very natural thing. He said, "hey if there's anything you guys ever want me to do I'll be there in five minutes." So I thought wow that's a pretty neat thing to say. And plus we liked him and we thought he was artistic too. So we got him to sing this song. And the people said, "oh they did it to commercialize." And I always thought well if we were going to do that song to be commercial the bridge wouldn't have been in thirteen or seventeen or whatever it was. It was the weirdest bridge in history. And of course the record company said okay give us a three minute and a half version of it that we can try and get on the radio, which they were unable to do. And I still thought the song was okay. I never thought — I thought the song was okay. But if it had done well that would have been okay too. But it wasn't calculated. That was the main thing. It was natural. It was stuff that was happening in the group. Like I started writing some songs, Future Man started singing some of them just to see what was happening. He's a good singer. Victor sings. It was like — and then plus the controversy of it was kind of fun. Oh this is really going to irritate some people so let's see what happens with that. But of course we wanted people to like it.

MR: And you're always going to irritate somebody I think, in the music business.

BF: Yeah. But I really understand like why somebody would say, "I don't buy Flecktone records to hear somebody sing pop songs." I totally can relate to that. And I was hoping that the songs would be good enough that it wouldn't matter. And I'm not sure that they were, I'm really not. But so we had one song on the next record, or maybe two. We had three on that record and then since then we haven't been having singing so much. This new record we just finished doesn't have any singing.

MR: Have you found that you relate pretty well to outside producers?

BF: We never had an outside producer. I produced the band from the very beginning.

MR: That's good. I think that's a luxury.

BF: Yeah I mean we've had pressure on us to have outside producers and early on I think Future Man was the one who didn't want to have any part of it. Because he had had some bad experiences, Victor and Future Man, the Wooten brothers. There's five of them. And they had a big deal at a certain point on Arista records and a fellow named Kashif who

produced I guess Whitney Houston and some other people and was producing them. And some bad things happened. Like they came in one day and Vic's parts had been replaced by another bass player or a keyboard, or things like that. And they felt very taken advantage of and they were very suspicious of producers. And so for Future Man, who is doing something very unusual, he didn't like the idea of some other person having a say about what he did. He was very un-into it at that point. And if it was the wrong producer that could have happened. But I was actually okay with it. I thought it would be neat to get like Daniel Lanois or somebody to help us paint a whole different sonic picture and go about things differently. But I've gotten really good at the technical part of taking the Flecktones into the studio and making it into a performance, you know, editing, doing things to capture the live moments and make a good take. We work really well as a team to do it and really we don't need somebody else in there. Although there's times it's good to bring something different to the music. I would try it I guess.

MR: Do you ever have trouble when you're doing studio recordings knowing when to stop? Knowing when something is actually finished?

BF: On our stuff?

MR: Yeah.

BF: Yeah. I don't know. I mean when I listen back to the records they don't sound warmed over to me. That would be the worry is that they were too slick or that there wasn't any life to them or something. Because I mean you know it's like, I don't know, there are some artists you see paintings and they're real rough and wild and the mis- — I don't want to call them mistakes — but the roughness is part of the greatness of it, and there's other painters who paint so fine it's like a photograph and it's so perfect and you love that about their work. I mean it's the prerogative of the artist to decide whether he wants his stuff to be like a really fine hundred year old bottle of wine or something newer that's a little rougher. I don't know. There's a lot of ways to describe it, whether you like really smooth silk or whether you like something, or a rough sweater or something. I mean they're both good, it's just, so I think with the Flecktones we're trying to — and also I think about the records in the studios as offsetting the live shows which we allow people to tape and distribute. That's the total, what we sound like live in person. That, everybody can check that out for free, that's out there. So we want the record to be different from that. We want it to be a more refined version of it. We want to use the records as a way to improve as musicians and to practice the music. A lot of times when you're recording you don't know the song that well so it's not like a performance where usually not only have you played the song enough to perform it in public but you're playing to an audience that's inspiring you to like make sure you really do it right. When you're in the studio sitting around with the guys it's different. And to get up to that level of intensity,

you might need to do it twenty times. Plus there's part of these songs that are hard and that's the time that the songs sometimes really come together is in the studio. So it's just part of the whole picture. It's like a postcard and then there's the everyday — we play this song at the show and how it changes. And sometimes we never play it as good as we got it on the record. Sometimes we never get it on the record because we do it live.

MR: Was it a hard decision to basically allow and almost encourage people to tape you in your concerts?

BF: No, I mean I think we just decided to do it right at the beginning, that we just decided to allow it. And it was a time when that was sort of starting to happen. And I guess Phish was an example to me. They were starting to build a huge audience and they were allowing taping and that seemed to be part of it, the Grateful Dead thing the whole sort of jam band thing was just starting. And it seemed like a neat thing to do. And plus we were all, being musicians that study a lot of a old music, we loved the fact that there are tapes of Charlie Parker and there are tapes of cool bluegrass bands, Bill Monroe, and Flatt & Scruggs and you name it. You know Chick Corea live videos. We love all that kind of stuff. So we were thinking how can we love all that stuff and tell people they couldn't have that of us? And then plus we found that we were playing so differently from night to night, it was cool if somebody showed up with a tape of a show from two years ago and we heard it, we'd go, "hey, that was cool." You know. I'm glad somebody got that. Because it's gone, it's into the ether and it's gone. So and then plus gradually you start to realize that a concert is a very personal thing for that night for that audience that's sitting there that night. That's what that concert is for. They're connected to it and it's cool for them to walk away with a version of it if they can get a hold of it, that's cool. But later when I got to know the guys in Phish and I found that they questioned their own decision to do that because they had a hard time having successful records because people traded the live tapes and then when they put out a record people would say, "oh that's just slick stuff they're trying to sell records with." And so they would have trouble and they weren't selling the kind of records that they wanted to sell and yet they were selling out Madison Square Garden. Which made me — I looked at that from the outside and I went, "you're a success. Your live show is an incredible success and it's just not following the normal template where it's about record sales and hit records. Your success is about drawing an audience and the way you got there was by trading these live tapes." And not only that in most cases people don't make money from their records anyway. The record company is funneling it off one way or another. The more success you have the more videos you do, the more costs come. But if your success is based on live touring nobody can take live touring money away from you. So it's actually a better business plan to build a great live touring base than to build a great record selling base. And so I just think

anything that encourages the live touring base, if you enjoy playing and you like going out and touring, then it's a wiser business plan with more longevity.

MR: The fellows that I talked to that were recording in the forties say basically the same thing, that they never made much money off the records, if any.

BF: Well there was a period where it seemed like I was making a ton of publishing money. But we'd never see any actual royalties. Because the publishing money comes from the first record. If you write a song and maybe it's a song that somebody, it's not even your song. So they have to pay that person. They can't hold that money up. Like they can hold the artist's money up on a record because whatever it cost to make a record they could say well I'm not going to pay you, Sonny Rollins. I'm not going to pay you until your record costs are paid off. And then they can manipulate the numbers so that it never happens or it happens and you just never know. But with the writer's royalties they have to come from the very first record sold. So I found that I was making good money from writer's royalties and seeing no record — none of the records went into — like at Warner Brothers it wasn't until after eight records and like a year or two after the eighth record came out that the whole account paid off. So for ten years there was no income whatsoever from actual record sales. But the fact that we were writing all this music we were seeing a lot. So we knew they were making a lot of money. And it was like 700,000 records or more on Warners, and we never saw any. But we also took the budgets. The budgets were considerable too.

MR: It must be nice when people from other groups and so forth, record some of your music that you've written.

BF: It doesn't happen very much. I can't think of —

MR: It's a high compliment.

BF: It doesn't happen very often. It's pretty rare. But for our stuff, because it's just such personal stuff.

MR: Very personal.

BF: But I love it. Love to see that happen.

MR: You had said in an article that the music often gets changed from the time it gets recorded until it gets to the consumer's hands. How does that happen?

BF: Well I guess I was talking about feeling the hand of somebody — once it gets recorded that's what it is. But sometimes by the time it gets recorded it's been shaped by hands other than the artists, and I think that's what I was talking about. Like for instance if the Flecktones had come up with some cool tune that we liked a lot and then we had a producer or a record company executive who said, "oh that part's too hard, that part's blah blah blah and you've got to change it like this and do this and you're going to have a hit." And then if we actually listen to them, which is what tends to happen — you know if

you get a producer they hire a producer because they have a track record for getting success, not necessarily because they do beautiful work. So that's what I'm talking about. So what's nice about the Flecktones is with me as the producer as long as my motives are pure then chances are if anything goes wrong it's just an honest, you know, bad taste or bad — but it's not from a motive of commerce or — I mean occasionally I might think it about that song, but generally I don't think I'm operating from that anymore. I don't think I ever was very much but more and more I feel kind of proud of not letting that — and then the nice thing about making records at home, where technology has come to, is you can take your time and get it the way you want it and it's not as expensive as it was and you really do have that kind of artistic control. Which in our case I think has been a really good thing. I mean you could argue that the right producer could have taken our career in a different direction or be playing in bigger places or have something that radio could play or something like that. But there are compromises that are inherent in that whole formula that I don't think anyone in our band thought we needed to do. Because we were doing better than we ever thought we were going to do anyway. And we have an audience, the gigs were good, we're making plenty of money doing weird art music that we love. What's the motivation? Usually I mean all you have to do is your kid has to be starving for you to change your motivation and throw away your idealistic lofty things. But none of us were in that situation. We weren't suffering for our art. We were like privileged. And it's felt like that since the beginning, that we've been privileged that we could do our music the way we wanted to do it and make a living and have an audience that loved us passionately for who we were. So again, where's the motivation to sell out? Just so you can be a bigger number on a chart or something? And more and more that stuff just seemed to be meaningless and shallow, and what seemed to have meaning was the fact that when we came out people showed up and that they thanked us for being honest with it and that they were moved by it. So to us that carried a lot of weight.

MR: I'm glad you said that because I had read you had used the word "overview" about your music. And you said it today already. And it sounds like you just described it, like you've really got a vision of what it is you guys do and want to continue doing.

BF: Yeah. Well it's an interesting time right now because we're about to stop the band for a year. And this is the first time we've done this since we got together in '88. And we started being a full time band in 1990 and we've been going nonstop for the whole time, always at least 150 shows a year and many more the first years. And so this year we've decided to take a hiatus and that's going to be — so it's going to be an interesting year for everybody to not be in the Flecktones for a while. And right now we're on the last four shows before we hang it up for while. We've got a new record that we've recorded that is going to come out when we come back so I mean like at the same time as the

motivations for things are not necessarily commerce or whatever, I'm also very thoughtful about existing in the world, in the business world. Like in other words, when we come back, it's going to be much better if we come back with a new record so that there's something to promote and something to talk about and new music to play. So I mean it's like I live in both worlds. I try to be very much of a realist and set the band up in the best possible way while keeping the music what we want it to be. So I thought it was good for us to squeeze out a record right now while we're playing like a lot. We had the whole last six months have been about working on new music so we're finishing up the year with a feeling of achievement. We just created a project we're really proud of and we're going to put it away for a while and we're all going to do different things.

MR: You do so much traveling. Are there trends that you've noticed in the country, either positive or negative, that have made an impression on you?

BF: We've seen — the music business is in a bad state right now. And I can't help but think it's connected to the political situation.

MR: How so?

BF: Well like I don't like to push my own political views because like now I'm getting to be more well known and stuff and I feel like a lot of people who aren't as well known don't get the same forum, so I feel like I like to be cautious about when I speak out. But I mean being at war is tough. Although I do remember there's been times when the country was at war where the entertainment business was booming. But this time here recently, especially around the election, and the whole six months leading up to the election was some of the worst I've seen since — at least since I've been in the Flecktones. But now it seems to be picking back up again, now that that decision finally got made, for better or for worse it seems like. Because normally I seem to remember that when times were bad it was often really good for the music business. I mean it doesn't matter a hill of beans in the big picture of what's going on in the world, whether the music business is doing good or not. I'm very aware of that. But I can't help but notice when crowds are off in places that used to be good. But then all of a sudden they're back. You know I see all those things. I think there's a lot of confusion and division right now about what the country should do and how we should approach being America. That's too bad. I mean I wish we could be more together about it.

MR: Your parents are still alive?

BF: Um hum.

MR: Do you think they had aspirations for you to be a musician?

BF: I don't know. I don't think so. But my father, who — it's a complicated story, I won't go into too much except that I only got to meet him and get to know him over the last few years, they split up when I was really young and he named me. They had a deal, if it was

a boy he would name us, and if it was a girl, my mother would name it. It was a strange arrangement they had. And they had two boys and I got Béla, which is not a bad situation considering my brother got Ludwig.

MR: Got what?

BF: Ludwig.

MR: Okay.

BF: Yeah. So my father was naming us after classical composers that he loved. So it's a complicated story. But anyway who knows? We're both musicians. We're both really musical people. So it's just bizarre. And we never heard from him.

MR: And your mother liked what kind of music? What would she play around the house?

BF: She played some folk guitar a little bit. Just a general open minded — not an incredibly musically oriented person although knows what she likes. We listened to a lot of Beatles when we were kids and everything that was going on in the sixties we were very into.

MR: As a leader of a group, do you ever have to make difficult decisions that make your bandmates unhappy?

BF: Once in a while, although everybody is really good. They really understand because they all lead themselves. They all have their own groups and situations that they have to make those kinds of decisions about and I think that they are pretty cool with most things. Usually everything is about accommodation. That's what the challenges are. Victor wants this time to do something. I've got a call to do this. Jeff might have this. Future Man might have this. But we have to work enough to keep this great crew that we have. We have these great guys that work with us that we've kept. Everyone who's ever come to work with us has stayed and so if we're all doing too many solo projects, I mean they're all great, fun things to do but you know there's also that feeling of responsibility to everybody. So generally the decisions that get made are always based on trying to take care of everybody in a situation so that it can have longevity. I was in a band where the leader was very uncomfortable with the people's solo work and he would become very uncomfortable and so I learned, and I was burgeoning with my own ideas and they didn't fit into the group and so I leaned from that, that even if it's uncomfortable to not try to control what people did. And for a long time I controlled what I did but I'd let everybody else do what they wanted but I couldn't do anything but the group. Because I felt like I was the name that people knew and I needed to send a real clear message that this is what I was doing. And I turned down a lot of cool things. And I always thought the other guys in the band, which had given up their whole other lives to be in this group that was largely my group, that I owed it to them to make that kind of commitment to them. They never seemed to actually feel that way. I discovered that they didn't mind if I did outside stuff at all. But I didn't feel like I should and so at a certain point I started to resent that

everybody in the group could get to do cool stuff outside the group but me, who had all these great opportunities I was turning down all the time. But I never talked to them about it. It was just something that was going on in my own head and gradually I realized that I had to take care of myself too, that I had to be part of the equation of making everybody happy. It wasn't just everybody else but me. It was me too. And that it turned out to not be an issue. Everybody is happy, like they were really happy when they heard the records that I did on my own, the bluegrass records or the classical records, or the things with Edgar [Meyer]. I think they like that I'm doing that kind of stuff.

MR: If someone brings a tune of their own to the group, they're emotionally invested in it, but it's just not a Flecktone song, is it really apparent to everybody?

BF: It's not always apparent. And it's the difficult thing about being a leader is that I might have that feeling but I have to be suspicious of myself too. Because I have to make sure that I haven't, maybe I don't think I sound good on it or something. But I have to sound good on it too. Or I might not think it's that great a song or something and I have to like, sometimes I have an instinctive thing, it's just, I just don't like it. And what am I going to do? Am I going to say something and like be a downer? Or am I going to try it for a while and see maybe I'm wrong? But usually I know right away if I think — but what I'm suspicious of about myself is that once I decide that I like it then I decide to like it. Or is it just an emotional thing on a day to day basis, it's decided. I don't know what it is but sometimes I hear something and I go hey that's great, let's do that, that's great. And at other times I hear something and I go um, doesn't sound special or I can't see it or I just don't like it. And I think that was one of the reasons Howard left the band. Because I wasn't that warm to his compositions. I found his compositions to be sometimes very technical or sometimes they seemed almost too sweet. One or the other. And so I had a hard time because at that time I was really fixed on the band doing exactly what I thought it should do and had a vision for the group. And those kinds of songs, I had trouble. Because I wanted to love them and I didn't love them. And that was hard for him because he's a great writer and the stuff was good. And so a lot of times his song wouldn't make a record and it was like oh, and I felt like wow, it's a hard decision but it's the right decision and now I would question whether that was the right decision. Maybe I should have found a way to make those songs work, done what I needed to do to feel better about them. Because his writing should have been more a part of things because he is a good writer. Interestingly, after he left the group and he started a group called Trio Globo, and I listened to those records, I heard songs of his that I liked a lot that I would have been happy to record. But at that time either I wasn't open to them or just those particular songs just didn't click with me or what. But it was a hard thing.

MR: You've probably played a number of times in well known music schools, universities and so forth. Do you wonder what some of the people that are majoring in jazz now and so forth are going to do when they get out? Knowing what you do about the music business?

BF: Yeah I think it's tough. I mean it's always the unusual characters that kind of do the best, the ones that don't follow the school, that don't follow the school of thought, that stepped outside of it in some way. And I don't know how you teach that. I mean I know how you teach somebody, you know you can teach somebody a technical aspect of things and then they have good technique and they have good ability, but I don't know how you teach creativity or teach somebody to write better tunes or write tunes that'll reach out to people. I don't know how you teach people to perform. I mean you don't want to go to like performing school and like have somebody like Brittany Spears, like where you get on a soundstage and then your teacher critiques your mouth movements while you're soloing, or that you don't reach out to the audience. But I mean you could do that. But if you're really going to teach skills that were going to help you be successful in music I would take a good hard look at how what you do reaches people. And that's more important than whether you actually can play the right scales in the songs and to your future as a performer. But you know if you can't play the right stuff, if you're playing jazz and you get a gig playing with good jazz guys and you can't cut the changes they're not going to want to call you and that's part of making it in show business too is working your way up to the point where you're in front of a audience and musicians around you wanting to work with you for some reason. Or that quality of being like the kind of musician that brings out the best in other musicians. Makes people want to have you around. That's the kind of stuff that you don't really hear about. Those are the things that — but in terms of the technical stuff, there's a lot of stuff I wish I knew that if I had spent three years at Berklee I would know, about getting through changes, the weird changes that come at me, or if I could read music. I don't read music well at all. Transcribe. Maybe had a broader musical palette to draw from.

MR: When you bring a tune to the band, or the other fellows, does it come notated or do you just kind of get together and —

BF: No. We just play it for each other.

MR: Say here's the changes?

BF: A lot of times we don't even do that. A lot of times it'll just be a sound check. Like today we'll get on stage, right now we're not really working on anything new because we've only got a few days left of the trip, but if I've got something I've been working on I might just start playing it. And then sometimes Future Man will be playing a beat and he'll fall in and he'll find it and then I might say, "oh well there's a new one here." And he'll go, oh. But for a long time I won't even say that because I'll just see what he does.

And sometimes he'll just sort of thread through it, and then Victor will start playing and if I'm behaving I won't even tell them what the notes are. But sometimes I can't help myself and I go oh, there's really an F sharp right there. Because a lot of times he'll just sort of play simply just until he sort of figures it out. Because I want him to harmonize it himself and find something that I wouldn't have naturally heard. Once I tell him what I'm hearing he's going to play it that way from then on, so then he'll be trapped by that structure. But sometimes he's found things that I never would have thought of. And Future Man same thing. "Sinister Minister" was supposed to be a Brazilian tune. But when I started playing it for Future Man he put that funk backbeat on it and it was like, if I had told him it was a Brazilian tune it would have never been what it ended up being. So I've tried to keep that in mind. And some songs you just have to tell a person it's a G sharp diminished chord, or it's not a minor chord it's a half diminished or it's — but their ears are so good.

MR: That's a great system. I mean again I think it takes — it's about ego.

BF: Yeah but also it's about like having time on stage everyday. The fact that we play so many gigs that we can sort of work our way into a song in a real kind of easygoing way, there's no big hurry. Except like when we're trying to make a record then there's a pressure and then I get a little more testy and picky, because I'm pushing everybody and I'm trying to shape everybody into this tight thing so that when we get in the studio we can just nail it. And I think that's hard to be around. When we're getting ready to record I think I'm harder to be around. But they all know me, you know, they know where I'm coming from and they know it'll be over and we'll come out with something good and that they'll have a lot of input and it'll be ours together I think. But I like to recognize it because I'm trying not to beat anybody up. Through the process I'm trying to get better at not —

MR: Is there is a time in musical history that you wish you could go back to in a time machine?

BF: Just to be there?

MR: Just to be hanging out and witness some of that?

BF: Yeah. A lot of the jazz eras, but also a lot of the bluegrass eras. It would have been great to see Bill Monroe, and Flatt & Scruggs playing together in their original bluegrass band. And also a lot of the earlier music before that, the early Louis Armstrong music is well known but a lot of other music that was happening around that time and then the slaves music, the music that was being played on banjos that the Africans that were brought over were playing. A big part of what I'm doing next year, I'm going to Africa for 4 to 6 weeks, to record an album and do some documentary stuff about where the banjo came from.

MR: Oh great.

BF: Because that's one of the things that I'm really interested in doing.

MR: West Africa or —?

BF: West Africa will be a big part of it but also East Africa just because I have a friend who does tours over there who knows a lot of musicians in Uganda and Tanzania. So that's going to be an interesting thing, which would have been hard to do in a regular Flecktone year because, you know, six weeks of not being available and then the time I'll need to recover. Six weeks is a long time for a band to be off when they're all trying to make a living. But for this year I'm going to be doing different things.

MR: You said something interesting I thought about bluegrass music is that it's not all that old, and it's not old enough to have rules.

BF: Yeah well I mean jazz is the same thing. Each era of jazz you could say wow that's not that old either. But they move through. The nice thing about jazz is that it moved through. You have like that Louis Armstrong thing but then it moved to another place. And then you have swing and then it worked into bebop and then it worked into, I don't know, Miles Davis and then Coltrane and Thelonious Monk and then it moved into "Bitches Brew" and the fusion era started, and then you've got neotraditionalism coming back and all that, which is a step backwards to me, even though there's a lot of great music being played. And bluegrass has done a lot of those same things. The truth is bluegrass has moved through things too. So I don't know which particular snapshot of the timeline you want to call the tradition, but I mean with bluegrass you have to start with the first bluegrass band, which at least one of those guys is still alive, maybe only one, Earl Scruggs, so an 80 year old guy, 82. So I don't know at what point it becomes a tradition. I guess I would think it would have to last for a century. I don't know what the definition is. But if you talk about Dixieland music or Louis Armstrong music, you know you could call that a tradition. And that hasn't been around much longer than bluegrass.

MR: Jazz has changed so much so fast.

BF: Yeah. And bebop, was that a tradition? I don't know. Or is it a style? It's a style. Maybe it's a style, not a tradition but it may become a tradition if people are still playing bebop in 2050, a hundred years from when it started. Maybe then, I don't know. I'm just making up a definition of what a tradition would be. I'm not sure. But when I think of a tradition I mean I think about Irish music. You know, centuries. But Bach has been played for centuries. Is that a tradition or is that a style or is that a particular composer? I don't know. I'm just asking. I don't know.

MR: If you could do a solo, you know you're working on a solo project and you could go back in music history and pick an artist who has passed away to play with you, who would that be?

BF: To play with me?

MR: Yeah.

BF: I don't know. Like a lot of those people I don't know if I could play — I love them, but I don't know if we'd play together or not. I don't think about it that way. But just going back to the tradition thing, if bluegrass is a tradition based on four guys, five guys that put together a band that was unprecedented that was so great that everybody is still imitating them, then are The Beatles a tradition too?

MR: Well people imitated them for sure.

BF: I mean is the thing that makes a thing a tradition is that it's imitatable?

MR: I don't know.

BF: I don't know.

MR: You should solve that and you could write a piece.

BF: I'm sure there's somebody that has a definition that would work. I'm sorry.

MR: That's all right. You've got four dates to go and then is everybody looking forward to the time off do you think?

BF: I think so. I think mixed, it's like you never know, a whole year is a long time, you never know what's going to happen so there's always that wonder, you know, will we ever all be together like this again. But then again we've done it so much, we've played together so much so if something happened and for some reason it didn't happen it wouldn't be like the Flecktone experiment was a failure or something. We've done fifteen years. My thing is when we come back together I want it to be new and fresh and everybody to come back and want to really do it. And I don't see any reason why that wouldn't happen. I honestly don't. But I'm looking forward to the things that I'm going to do and with mixed excitement and fear. Like I've got this trio I'm supposed to do. It's Stanley Clarke and Jean Luc Ponty, which is going to be an interesting thing. I mean they're great musicians but we've never played together and we've got all these big gigs coming up next summer and I don't know what we're going to sound like. So it's exciting and frightening. And then I'm going to have a bluegrass band, a trio that I'm putting together also that I'm really looking forward to. I can't see that being anything but fun. That's what I thought was the only thing I was going to do this year is just play some bluegrass festivals and have a real light year but then this opportunity came into place and then all of a sudden it's turning into a busy year. So it'll be interesting.

MR: So it won't all be rest.

BF: What's that?

MR: It won't all be rest.

BF: It won't be rest, yeah, I don't think it'll be much rest. But I think it'll be potentially a year where as a musician I would progress and then hopefully come back with some different ideas about how the Flecktones will go into the next period.

MR: Just to wrap up, you had mentioned that you guys don't get radio play, which is sort of distressing but I'm wondering is it because people have a hard time defining what you do?

BF: Yeah. Like for instance if you've got a straight ahead jazz show we're too something, we're not a straight ahead jazz group. And if you have a contemporary jazz show that tends to be smooth jazz, we're not smooth jazz so that knocks us out of jazz play unless you just have college or more occasional stations that do more unusual programming. And we get played on some of those. Or then NPR occasionally. But again, where is the broad heading that every town has that kind of station and you're on it regularly? That doesn't happen. Bluegrass shows play some of my stuff. But you know it's more of a public radio type inconsistent airplay thing. It's not that we don't get played at all but it's not a big factor. It's not like if you had a hit single or something, that nothing like that has happened since the very beginning.

MR: The Internet's probably been helpful to your band.

BF: Probably. But although some people feel like the trading of the records has been harmful to the records that you put money into that are not paid off, are being traded for free. That's a problem we're all dealing with that I don't really know what the answer is to.

MR: The cat's out of the bag on that one.

BF: Yeah. And that's why making them at home is a big deal and why being on major label may not make sense in a few years. Getting a big budget for a record that's going to get pirated and traded for free is going to be hard for them to justify after a while unless some solution comes up.

MR: Well I appreciate your time today.

BF: It was fun talking about it, I don't get to very often.

MR: In all the interviews you've ever done is there a question that you'd like to be asked that no one's asked?

BF: Not really.

MR: Okay. I just thought I would —

BF: No people ask me that too and I just tend to be responsive and go wherever it goes.

MR: And Nashville's still your home?

BF: Um hmm.

MR: When you can get back there.

BF: Yeah. Not much lately.

MR: All right.

BF: Okay.

MR: Well I'll look forward to hearing you tonight, and I hope your year off is really productive.

BF: Yeah I think it's going to be really fun and I'm going to miss the guys too.

MR: All right thanks for your time.

BF: Okay. Thank you.